FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

From the tip of Great Nicobar, Indonesia is only 140 km away. The Indian mainland, by contrast, lies at the end of a 1,600 km voyage. North of the Andaman, Myanmar is within 140 km; Thailand is 650 km due east. This play of distance and proximity has shaped the fate of this slim, boomerang-shaped archipelago. For millennia, secured against any disturbance, a unique ecological niche developed here. Evolution unfolded in a pristinely insular setting, yielding a bequest of flora and fauna found nowhere else on the planet. This geographical setting is now also proving to be its bane. On February 16, the National Green Tribunal (NGT) cleared the Rs 81,000 crore Great Nicobar Island Project, a massive port-airport-township complex that could change the face of the island for good—or bad. The NGT cited "national importance" to rationalise its verdict. The seed idea, conceived by NITI Aayog in 2020, has ambitious naval-strategic and commercial stakes built into it. India hopes to anchor itself astride what is often described as "the world's busiest maritime highway". The environmental stakes, however, resist monetary valuation.

The sanction is a qualified one, with a sieve of safeguards. But even if the legal battle fought by environmentalists like Ashish Kothari has not entirely been in vain, it does not quell their deep unease, shared in these days of violent climate change by ever-larger sections of the public. Both sides have striking arguments. The project's centrepiece is a Rs 44,000 crore international transhipment port in Galathea Bay. The idea is seductive. Outside of Vizhinjam on the west coast, India doesn't have deepwater ports and shells out over $200 million (Rs 1,800 crore) annually to Colombo and Singapore. Nicobar creates, literally out of the blue, a strategic linchpin overlooking the Strait of Malacca. Besides servicing India, it eyes a vital maritime axis that conducts up to one-third of all global sea-borne trade by value. Galathea's 20-metre depth can handle the largest 'mother ships'; they need to make near-zero deviation from their existing routes. With China breathing down India's neck from Myanmar's Kyaukpyu port and Coco Islands, the case for a spot of tactical sea control also seems compelling. An integrated complex with an international airport would project India's commercial and military presence in the eastern Indian Ocean.



▲ Mar. 11, 2024

The counterargument is equally forceful. Great Nicobar is a 921 sq. km biodiversity hotspot that's home to over 1,800 animal and 650 plant species. Two facets make it irreplaceable. It's a tropical 'refugium' for species that went extinct elsewhere. Others evolved only here, in a zone of extremely high endemism. Over 30 of its 60 mammals, up to a third of its 300-odd bird species, well over half of its 2,500-odd tree and plant species, and much of its smaller fauna are unique. Many are endangered, like the ground-dwelling bird Megapode, the Long-Tailed Macaque, the Serpent Eagle and the Treeshrew. Galathea is also one of the most precious nesting areas for the iconic Leatherback sea turtle. This is the ecological treasure trove that now faces an existential threat. The ultra-modern project also falls squarely in Seismic Zone V; the epicentre of the 9.1 Richter tsunami quake of 2004 was just 130 km away.

The proposed mitigation measures call for eternal vigil: cordoning off the turtle's nesting spots, for instance. The island is fringed by some of the world's most vibrant coral reefs, with 309 species. Official remedies waver between translocation and suggesting Galathea's waters do not host major colonies. The project will also clear 130 sq. km of dense tropical forest: 'a million trees'. Compensatory afforestation in Haryana borders on the ludicrous, even if in line with the law. In an interview with INDIA TODAY, Union environment minister Bhupender Yadav defends the project, saying it will leave intact "82 per cent of the forests" while creating an "economic hub".

The human dimension complicates matters further. The island is home to the Shompen and Nicobarese communities. The British colonialists did not make a pretence of seeking tribal consent before enacting policies that ended up depopulating them, but the Indian state has a system in place. The path has been grey. A tribal council has withdrawn its 2022 consent, alleging coercion and misguidance, including of the Shompen, a 'Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Group', whose consent was granted on their behalf by a government-run society. The procedural labyrinths through which the project obtained clearance have been criticised for being opaque and inadequate.

Team India Today's cover story, a truly collective effort, is an exhaustive overview. The strategic case is ambitious. The environmental cost is irreversible. Even in its most bullish projections, it's not a given that Nicobar can outrival Singapore or Colombo. The question is whether India is prepared to risk an ecological inheritance for a commercial and geopolitical wager whose returns are uncertain. This is not a simple contest between development and conservation. It is a test of how a rising power balances strategic aspiration with ecological responsibility.

The world has seen a long list of fragile hotspots imperilled by human overreach, from the Amazon to the Congo to the Indonesian rainforests. Great Nicobar stands at a similar crossroads. The decision will reveal not only how India defines national importance, but also how it values what cannot be recreated once lost.

(Aroon Purie)